

# English Grammar for the UPSC Vice Principal CRT: Rules UPSC Actually Tests

अंग्रेज़ी व्याकरण: UPSC उप-प्रधानाचार्य परीक्षा के लिए

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## English Grammar for the UPSC Vice Principal CRT

**How UPSC tests English in this paper**

**The English section is quick marks if you know about twelve rule families; it is not a literature test.**

The syllabus line is only "Hindi and English language skills" (Advt. 51/2026, Appendix-I). The closest previous paper (VP RT, 11 Dec 2022) has not yet been analysed in this folder, so the table below is the standard objective-English pattern used in recruitment tests, not a confirmed breakdown of the UPSC paper:

| Question type                                             | What is really being tested                   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Spot the error (sentence split into 3 parts + "No error") | Agreement, tense, preposition, article        |
| Fill in the blank                                         | Preposition, article, tense, conjunction pair |
| Sentence improvement                                      | Idiomatic usage, "No improvement" trap        |
| Active/passive, direct/indirect                           | Fixed transformation rules                    |
| Synonym, antonym, idiom, one-word substitution            | Vocabulary                                    |
| Sentence rearrangement, short passage                     | Reading logic                                 |

With **one-third negative marking** (each wrong answer loses one-third of that question's marks; a blank costs nothing), attempt only the items where you can name the rule. The rules below are the ones that generate the wrong options.

### Subject-verb agreement

**The verb agrees with the real subject, not with the noun standing nearest to it.**

- Words between subject and verb do not change the number: *The **list** of candidates **is** ready.*
- "as well as", "along with", "together with", "in addition to", "no less than", "and not": the verb agrees with the **first** subject. *The Principal, as well as the teachers, **was** present.*

- **"either...or", "neither...nor", "not only...but also":** the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject. *Neither the Principal nor the teachers **were** informed.*
- **"each", "every", "either", "neither", "anyone", "everyone", "nobody"** take a **singular** verb and a singular pronoun. *Each of the boys **has** done **his** work.*
- **"one of the" + plural noun + singular verb:** *One of the **students has** failed.* The clause after "who" agrees with the plural noun: *One of the students **who were** punished has apologised.*
- **"A number of" = plural verb; "The number of" = singular verb.** *A number of teachers **are** absent.*  
*The number of absentees **is** large.*
- **Collective nouns** (committee, staff, jury, government) are singular when acting as one unit, plural when members act separately.
- **Uncountable nouns are always singular:** furniture, information, advice, luggage, news, scenery, machinery, poetry, evidence, and hair (meaning all the hair on the head). Never "furnitures" or "an advice"; say "a piece of advice". ("Hairs" is correct only for individual strands: *two grey hairs*.)
- **Plural-only nouns:** scissors, trousers, spectacles, premises, thanks, proceeds, alms. *The premises **were** inspected.*
- **Plural in form, singular in meaning:** news, mathematics, physics, economics, politics (as a subject), measles. *Mathematics **is** my subject.*

- **Distances, sums, periods** as one amount take a singular verb: *Ten thousand rupees **is** a big sum.*  
*Five kilometres **is** a long walk.*
- **"Many a" + singular noun + singular verb:** *Many a student **has** tried.*

## Tenses and sequence of tenses

**Time words fix the tense; and a past main clause normally pulls the subordinate clause into the past.**

| Time marker                                      | Tense required                           |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| yesterday, last year, in 2020, ago               | Simple past ( <i>went</i> )              |
| since, for, already, just, yet, so far, recently | Present perfect ( <i>has gone</i> )      |
| by the time X happens, by 2027                   | Future perfect ( <i>will have gone</i> ) |
| when X came (another past action already over)   | Past perfect ( <i>had gone</i> )         |
| while, at that moment                            | Continuous ( <i>was going</i> )          |

Key rules:

- **Never use the present perfect with a definite past time word.** *He has joined in 2019* is wrong; *He joined in 2019* or *He has been here since 2019* is right.
- **Present perfect is never used with "ago" or "yesterday".**
- **Sequence of tenses:** a past tense in the main clause takes a past tense in the subordinate clause. *He said that he **was** tired.* Exceptions: **universal truths, habitual facts, and "than" comparisons** keep their

own tense. *The teacher said that the earth **revolves** round the sun.*

- **Two past actions:** the earlier one takes **past perfect**. *The train **had left** before we **reached** the station.*
- "**Had better**", "**would rather**", "**must**", "**should**" are followed by the **bare infinitive**: *You **had better** leave now.*
- After "**if**", "**when**", "**unless**", "**till**", "**as soon as**", "**before**" in a future sense, use the **simple present**, not "**will**". *I will call you when he **comes**.*
- **Stative verbs** (know, believe, own, belong, understand, like, seem) are not normally used in continuous forms. *I am knowing him* is wrong.

## Articles and determiners

"**A/an**" depends on the first sound, not the first letter; "**the**" marks a known or unique thing.

- "**an**" before a vowel **sound**: an hour, an honest man, an MLA, an M.A., an FIR, an X-ray. "**a**" before a consonant **sound**: a university, a union, a European, a one-rupee coin, a useful book.
- "**The**" is used with: superlatives (**the** best), ordinals (**the** first), unique objects (**the** sun), rivers, seas, oceans, mountain ranges, deserts, plural country names (**the** Netherlands, **the** USA), holy books (**the** Gita), newspapers (**the** Hindu), musical instruments (plays **the** sitar), adjectives used as nouns for a whole class (**the** rich, **the** poor), and nationalities as a group (**the** French).

- **No article** before: names of languages, subjects, meals, diseases, abstract nouns in a general sense, and the words school, college, church, hospital, bed, prison when used for their **purpose** (*go to school*; but *go to the school to meet the Principal*).
- "**Few / little**" = hardly any (negative). "**A few / a little**" = some (positive). "**The few / the little**" = all that there is.
- "**Each**" is used for two or more; "**every**" for three or more. "**Either/neither**" are for **two** only; for more than two use "**any / none**".
- "**Fewer**" with countable nouns, "**less**" with uncountable: *fewer students, less time*.
- "**Elder / eldest**" only for family members and only attributively (*my elder brother*); "**older / oldest**" for everything, and only "older" takes "than". *He is elder than me* is wrong.

## Prepositions and conjunctions

Most preposition errors come from a short list of fixed pairs.

| Correct usage                                                            | Common wrong form                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| senior / junior / superior / inferior / prior / preferable <b>to</b>     | senior <b>than</b>                              |
| different <b>from</b> ; similar <b>to</b>                                | different <b>than</b>                           |
| responsible <b>to</b> a person <b>for</b> a thing                        | responsible <b>for</b> a person                 |
| agree <b>with</b> a person, <b>to</b> a proposal                         | agree <b>to</b> a person                        |
| consist <b>of</b> ; comprise (no "of")                                   | comprise <b>of</b>                              |
| die <b>of</b> a disease, <b>from</b> a wound, <b>for</b> a cause         | die <b>with</b>                                 |
| married <b>to</b> ; angry <b>with</b> a person, <b>at</b> a thing        | married <b>with</b>                             |
| discuss, order, attack, resemble, enter, reach + object (no preposition) | discuss <b>about</b> , enter <b>into</b> a room |
| since + point of time; for + period                                      | since two hours                                 |
| between two; among more than two                                         | between the three                               |
| in time (before the deadline); on time (exactly)                         | —                                               |
| beside = next to; besides = in addition to                               | —                                               |

Correlative conjunctions must be in pairs and placed in parallel positions: **either...or, neither...nor, not only...but also, both...and, hardly/scarcely...when, no sooner...than, so...that, such...that, as...as, so...as (negative), lest...should.**

- *No sooner had the bell rung **than** the students left.*  
Never "no sooner...then".

- *Hardly had he entered **when** the phone rang.* Never "hardly...than".
- "**Unless**" already contains "not": *Unless you work hard, you will fail.* Never "unless you do not".
- "**Lest**" takes "**should**": *Work hard lest you **should** fail.*
- Do not use "**although...but**" or "**because...so**" together in one sentence.

## Pronouns, adjectives and adverbs

The case of a pronoun depends on its job in the clause; comparison words follow fixed patterns.

- After "**than**" and "**as**", use the subject form when a verb is understood: *He is taller than I (am).* Exam keys follow this formal rule.
- After **prepositions and transitive verbs**, use the object form: *between you and **me**; let **him** and **me** go.*
- Order of persons: **231 for normal, 123 for admitting a fault.** *You, he and I will go. I, you and he are to blame.*
- "**Who**" is subject, "**whom**" is object: *the teacher **whom** we met; the teacher **who** met us.*
- "**Whose**" can be used for persons and things; "**which**" never for persons.
- "**One...one's**": *One should do **one's** duty,* not "his duty".
- "**Each other**" for two, "**one another**" for more than two.

- A **relative pronoun** must stand next to its antecedent.
- **Double comparatives/superlatives** are wrong: *more better, most tallest.*
- **"Than"** after comparatives; but **"prefer...to"**: *I prefer tea **to** coffee.*
- Comparing one item with the rest of its group needs **"any other"**: *Delhi is bigger than **any other** city in India.*
- Adjectives that have no degrees: **unique, perfect, complete, round, universal, full, empty.** "More unique" is wrong.
- Verbs of sense (look, smell, taste, feel, sound) take an **adjective**, not an adverb: *The soup tastes **good**.*
- **"Hardly / scarcely"** mean almost not; **"hard"** is the adverb of effort. *He works **hard**; he **hardly** works.*
- **"Very"** modifies adjectives and present participles; **"much"** modifies comparatives and past participles: *very interesting, much surprised, much better.* But past participles that have become ordinary adjectives take "very": *very tired, very pleased.* In modern usage *very interested* is also standard, so do not mark it wrong unless every other option is clearly correct.

### Active and passive voice

Keep the tense, change the object into the subject, and use the correct form of "be" + past participle.

| Active           | Passive               |
|------------------|-----------------------|
| writes           | is written            |
| is writing       | is being written      |
| wrote            | was written           |
| was writing      | was being written     |
| has written      | has been written      |
| had written      | had been written      |
| will write       | will be written       |
| can / must write | can / must be written |

Rules examiners use for wrong options:

- Only **transitive** verbs have a passive. *He sleeps* has no passive.
- **Perfect continuous and future continuous** tenses are not normally changed to passive.
- Imperatives: *Open the door.* → *Let the door **be opened**.* / *You are requested to open the door* (for requests).
- Questions keep the question form: *Who wrote this?* → ***By whom** was this written?*
- Verbs with two objects can take either as the passive subject: *The Principal gave him a prize.* → *He was given a prize / A prize was given to him.*
- Some verbs take prepositions other than "by": *known **to**, surprised **at**, pleased **with**, interested **in**, filled **with**.*
- Modal passives: *The form must be filled in* (phrasal verbs keep their particle).

## Direct and indirect speech

Shift the tense one step back, change the pronouns to the reporter's view, and replace "here-and-now" words.

| Direct                   | Indirect                             |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| present simple           | past simple                          |
| present continuous       | past continuous                      |
| present perfect          | past perfect                         |
| past simple              | past perfect                         |
| will / shall / can / may | would / should / could / might       |
| must                     | had to (or must for permanent rules) |

Word changes: **now** → **then**; **today** → **that day**; **yesterday** → **the previous day / the day before**; **tomorrow** → **the next day**; **ago** → **before**; **here** → **there**; **this** → **that**; **these** → **those**; **come** → **go** (only where the sense requires it); **last night** → **the previous night**.

- No tense change if the reporting verb is in the **present or future**, or if the reported speech is a **universal truth**.
- **Questions**: "said to" becomes **asked**; the sentence becomes a statement in word order (no "did", no question mark). Yes/no questions take **"if / whether"**; wh-questions keep the wh-word. *She said to me, "Where do you live?"* → *She asked me where I lived.*
- **Commands and requests**: "said to" becomes **ordered, told, requested, advised**, followed by **"to"**

+ **infinitive**; negative commands use "**not to**".

*"Don't talk," the teacher said to the boys → The teacher told the boys **not to talk**.*

- **Exclamations**: use *exclaimed with joy/sorrow that*.  
**Wishes**: *wished that*. "**Let us**" proposals: *suggested / proposed that we should*.

## Conditionals, modals and question tags

There are three conditional patterns, and the tag always reverses the sign of the main clause.

| Type | If-clause             | Main clause                     | Meaning           |
|------|-----------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------|
| 1    | simple present        | will + verb                     | real / likely     |
| 2    | simple past<br>(were) | would + verb                    | unreal<br>present |
| 3    | past perfect          | would have + past<br>participle | unreal past       |

- Formal exams expect "**If I were**" for all persons in Type 2, not "If I was".
- Never put "**will**" or "**would**" in the if-clause: *If it will rain* is wrong.
- **Inversion** can replace "if": *Had I known, I would have come*.

Modals: "**can**" = ability/permission; "**may**" = possibility/formal permission; "**must**" = obligation; "**should / ought to**" = duty; "**used to**" = past habit now stopped; "**need not**" + bare infinitive = no necessity; "**dare not**" + bare infinitive. The past of "must" in reported speech is "**had to**".

Question tags:

- Positive statement → **negative tag**; negative statement → **positive tag**. Use the **same auxiliary** and a **pronoun**. *The teachers are here, **aren't they?***
- "I am" → "aren't I". "Let us" → "shall we".  
Imperatives → "will you / won't you". "Let him go" → "will you".
- Words like **hardly, seldom, never, nobody, little, few** make the statement negative, so the tag is positive: *He seldom comes late, **does he?***
- "**Everybody, nobody, someone**" take "**they**" in the tag: *Everyone passed, **didn't they?***

**Vocabulary: idioms, one-word substitutions and spelling**

**Learn the high-frequency list; these items are pure recall.**

High-frequency idioms in competitive-exam English:

| Idiom                     | Meaning                         |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------|
| take with a pinch of salt | accept with doubt               |
| a red-letter day          | an important, memorable day     |
| at the eleventh hour      | at the last moment              |
| beat about the bush       | avoid the main point            |
| a white elephant          | a costly but useless possession |
| in the same boat          | in the same difficulty          |
| hit the nail on the head  | say exactly the right thing     |
| once in a blue moon       | very rarely                     |
| turn a deaf ear           | refuse to listen                |
| a bolt from the blue      | a sudden shock                  |
| throw cold water on       | discourage                      |
| burn the midnight oil     | study late at night             |
| call a spade a spade      | speak plainly                   |
| by leaps and bounds       | very rapidly                    |
| a hard nut to crack       | a difficult problem or person   |

One-word substitutions that suit an education paper:  
**pedagogue** (a teacher), **pedagogy** (the science of teaching), **curriculum** (course of study), **alumnus / alumni** (former student / students), **philanthropist** (lover of mankind), **misanthrope** (hater of mankind), **omniscient** (all-knowing), **omnipotent** (all-powerful), **ambidextrous** (able to use both hands), **illegible** (cannot be read), **inaudible** (cannot be heard), **truant** (child who stays away from school without leave), **autobiography** (life story written by oneself),

**anonymous** (unknown name), **posthumous** (after death), **unanimous** (all agreeing), **veteran** (long experienced), **novice** (beginner), **optimist / pessimist**, **plagiarism** (copying another's work as one's own).

Commonly tested spellings: **accommodate**, **committee**, **millennium**, **occurrence**, **separate**, **privilege**, **liaison**, **maintenance**, **harass**, **embarrass**, **recommend**, **questionnaire**, **supersede**, **pronunciation**, **definitely**, **grammar**, **bureaucracy**, **exaggerate**, **conscientious**, **guarantee**.

### **Sentence rearrangement and comprehension technique**

**Find the opener and the link words; most jumbles have one obvious first sentence and one obvious last sentence.**

- The first sentence introduces a noun by its full name; later sentences use **pronouns (it, they, this)**, **articles ("the" scheme)** and **connectors (however, therefore, also, thus, finally)**.
- Pair sentences that share a noun. Check every option code against two sure links rather than reading all four orders.
- In comprehension, read the questions first, then the passage. Answers must come **only from the passage**, even if your own knowledge differs.
- Vocabulary-in-context questions: substitute each option in the sentence and keep the one that preserves the meaning.

## Common traps

- **Nearest noun agreement:** *The quality of the answers **were** poor* is wrong; the subject is "quality".
- **"The number of" with a plural verb:** wrong. "A number of" is plural; "the number of" is singular.
- **Present perfect + past time word:** *has joined in 2019* is wrong.
- **"Senior than", "different than", "comprise of", "discuss about", "enter into the room":** all wrong in formal exams.
- **"No sooner...then" and "hardly...than":** wrong pairs. Correct: no sooner...than; hardly...when.
- **"Unless...not" and "lest...will":** wrong. Unless is already negative; lest takes should.
- **"If I was" and "if...will":** formal keys want "if I were" and a present tense after "if".
- **"More better", "most unique":** double comparison and absolute adjective.
- **"Elder than":** "elder" never takes "than"; use "older than".
- **Indirect speech with "yesterday" or "did":** the reported question must lose "did" and change "yesterday" to "the previous day".
- **Imperative narration without "to":** "told the boys not talk" is wrong; it is "not to talk".
- **"No error" / "No improvement"** is a real option and is sometimes the key. Choose it only if you cannot name a rule that is broken.

- **Tag with "Let us":** it is "shall we", never "will we" or "don't we".
- **Each other / one another, between / among, few / a few, less / fewer:** the pairs are tested as swaps.
- **Uncountable nouns in the plural:** "furnitures, informations, advices, sceneries, luggages" are always wrong ("hairs" is right only for individual strands).

### Remember for the exam

1. Verb agrees with the real subject; **as well as / along with** take the first subject, **either...or / neither...nor** take the nearer subject.
2. **Each, every, everyone, nobody, many a, one of the** take a **singular** verb.
3. **A number of** = plural; **the number of** = singular.
4. **Furniture, information, advice, news, luggage, hair** are singular; **scissors, trousers, premises** are plural.
5. Present perfect never goes with **yesterday, ago, in 2019**.
6. Two past actions: the earlier takes **past perfect**.
7. After **if / when / unless / as soon as** for the future, use **simple present**.
8. **An** before a vowel sound: an hour, an MLA, an honest man; **a** before a consonant sound: a university, a one-rupee note, a European.
9. **Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior, preferable** take **to**; different takes **from**.

10. **No sooner...than; hardly / scarcely...when; lest... should; unless** (never with "not").
11. Type 2 conditional: **If I were..., I would...;** never "will" in the if-clause.
12. Passive = same tense, **be + past participle;** questions become **By whom...?;** imperatives become **Let...be + past participle.**
13. Indirect speech: one tense back; **yesterday → the previous day, tomorrow → the next day, ago → before, now → then;** questions lose "did" and take **if / whether** or the wh-word.
14. Question tags reverse the sign: **I am → aren't I; Let us → shall we; imperatives → will you;** hardly / seldom / never make the tag positive.
15. **Elder / eldest** only for family and never with "than"; **older than** for all.

### Quick facts

- With 'as well as', 'along with', 'together with' and 'in addition to', the verb agrees with the **FIRST** subject; with 'either...or' and 'neither...nor' it agrees with the **NEARER** subject.
- 'Each', 'every', 'everyone', 'nobody', 'many a' and 'one of the + plural noun' all take a singular verb.
- 'A number of' takes a plural verb; 'the number of' takes a singular verb.
- Furniture, information, advice, news, luggage, scenery, hair (the mass on the head) and evidence are uncountable and singular;

scissors, trousers, spectacles and premises are always plural.

- Present perfect (has done) is never used with a definite past time word such as yesterday, ago, last year or in 2019.
- Of two past actions, the earlier one takes the past perfect: 'The train had left before we reached.'
- After 'if', 'when', 'unless', 'as soon as' and 'before' in a future sense, use the simple present, never 'will'.
- 'An' goes before a vowel SOUND (an hour, an MLA, an honest man); 'a' before a consonant sound (a university, a European, a one-rupee coin).
- Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior and preferable take 'to'; 'different' takes 'from'; 'responsible' takes 'to' a person and 'for' a thing.
- Fixed pairs: no sooner...than; hardly/scarcely...when; lest...should; 'unless' is already negative so never add 'not'.
- Type 2 conditional uses 'If I were..., I would...'; Type 3 uses 'If I had..., I would have...'; 'will' never appears in the if-clause.
- Passive keeps the tense and uses be + past participle; a 'Who...?' question becomes 'By whom...?'; an imperative becomes 'Let ... be + past participle'.

- In indirect speech, tenses go one step back and now→then, today→that day, yesterday→the previous day, tomorrow→the next day, ago→before, here→there.
- Question tags reverse the sign of the statement: 'I am' → 'aren't I'; 'Let us' → 'shall we'; imperatives → 'will you'; hardly/seldom/never make the statement negative so the tag is positive.
- 'Elder/eldest' are used only for family members and never with 'than'; use 'older than'. 'Fewer' goes with countable nouns and 'less' with uncountable nouns.